PUNJAB

The Sikh Clergy Turmoil

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

In the past four months, Sikhism's three key politico-religious institutions—the Akal Takht, the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC) and the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD)—have plunged into turmoil. This institutional flux has created a dangerous void that experts warn could embolden radical elements in Punjab's socio-political landscape.

The Akal Takht is the highest of the five seats of authority in Sikhism, with its jathedar or ordained leader holding a stature akin to the Pope in Catholicism. The SGPC, which manages key gurdwaras across Punjab, Himachal Pradesh, Jammu & Kashmir and Chandigarh, has historically appointed the Akal Takht jathedar. Meanwhile, the SAD, a dominant Sikh political party, has wielded considerable influence over both institutions. Together, these entities have shaped Sikh religious and political life for decades.

The crisis began on December 2, when the jathedars of all five Takhts, led by then Akal Takht chief Giani Raghbir Singh, demanded that the SAD accept Sukhbir Singh Badal's resignation from the post of party president, sack its top leadership and initiate a new membership drive. While Sukhbir underwent religious punishment—after being declared *tankhaiya* (excommunicated) for alleged mistakes committed during the SAD rule (2007-17)—and Balwinder Singh Bhunder took over as the party's working president, the membership drive has made little progress.

By mid-February, the storm was blowing inward. The SGPC sacked Giani Harpreet Singh, jathedar of Takht Damdama Sahib. Raghbir Singh objected, following which SGPC chief Harjinder Singh Dhami resigned from his post. It was only after much persuasion by Akali leaders, including Sukhbir, that he withdrew his resignation on March 18. But the crisis had already escalated: on March 7, the SGPC executive committee dismissed Raghbir Singh and Takht Kesgarh Sahib jathedar Giani Sultan Singh. As trigger for this bold step, it cited the Akal Takht jathedar's "failure to guide the *panth* (Sikh community) and address contemporary issues effectively".

Accusations of vendetta politics soon rent the air. The dismissed jathedars had played a key role in imposing a stringent *tankha* (religious punishment) on Sukhbir. Radicals have seized on this instability, arguing that the SGPC's actions reflect the influence of the Badal family, and lack legitimacy. The degree



PAST CAMARADERIE SGPC chief Harjinder Singh Dhami with then newly anointed Akal Takht jathedar Giani Raghbir Singh in June 2023

PRABHJOT GILL

INSTITUTIONAL FLUX

- **The Akal Takht, SGPC and the SAD face turmoil with dismissals and resignations that have left a power vacuum**
- **Institutional instability has seen radical pro-Khalistan voices gain traction, protest the SGPC's authority**
- **Structural reforms are imperative to restore both stability and credibility**